

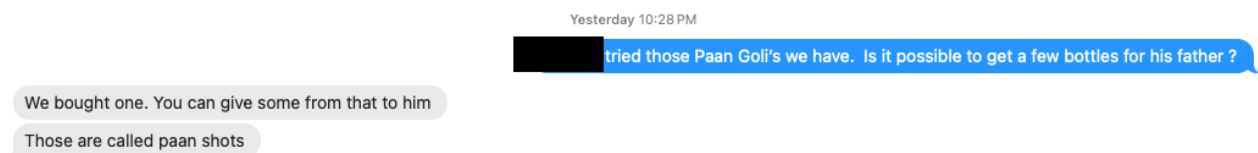
Paan Shots! The Economic Impact of Misinterpretation: A Father-Son Mini Case Study

By: Atishay

I recently returned from college for summer vacation. One of my “coming-back-home” rituals is indulging in Honest’s garlic naan, paneer, and ice-cold Diet Coke. I go quarterly with my buddy for one of the top meals on the planet.

After our meal, we returned home where I made him try some paan shots my parents picked up from crazy niche street vendors hidden in the streets of Old Delhi. By the way, paan shots are not alcoholic shots of paan (though I guarantee you the newest Indian restaurant trending on social media in Manhattan is serving them) but rather small tablets of various Indian sweets, seeds, and herbs mixed together. It’s quite wonderful, search them up.

Upon trying the paan shots, he remarks how his father would appreciate the authentic taste of them. I then texted my father, asking if he would be able to acquire a few flasks for my friend’s father, upon which my father responded below:



Name blurred out for privacy reasons.

I had immediately started thinking of the logistics of how we would take out only a few individual paan shots. I did not want to stress my parents out, knowing they were getting ready to travel back home after a long and exhausting trip, though I also knew I *could* have simply asked my parents to arrange a Blinkit order and they would not feel burdened by it. Having an awareness of both paradoxes simultaneously often makes it difficult to pick how to act.

Regarding this scenario, I optimized for a win-win-win solution:

1. I was bored at home, so now I had a mini challenge of figuring out how to have paan shots delivered to my parents who were staying in a neighborhood in East Delhi.
2. My parents would not be burdened with additional added stressors, in an already stressful time.
3. My friend's father would be able to enjoy a taste of home.

I immediately thought of who to contact in India. I turned to my cousin who is from India visiting me at home – he said no. I asked him if he could arrange it through his friends – he said no. I then thought of one of my technologically adept cousins, then another cousin, and then one of my cousin's wives. I texted all three of them via WhatsApp, then I realized it was too early in the morning for them and wouldn't respond.

I then thought of texting this group chat of friends I have who are international Indian students and have Indian phone numbers. One of them immediately helped me out, ordered it from his Indian phone number, paid for it from his UPI, to which I Zelled him.

I used my mother's Indian phone number to serve as the contact for the driver.

After everything was sorted, I contacted my father and told him I had set up the Blinkit order — but before I had a chance to say that, he had told me he already set up the order himself. Internally annoyed by the timing of it (as I lost the opportunity to prove him wrong) I then told him I had been originally calling to tell him that I had set up the order already, to which he said, “you should have told me about it first!” I found this initial reaction to be interesting as it was expected — after all, his fatherly instinct kicked in. I then explained my process and asked him to cancel the order.

After a few phone calls between my mother and father, they finally received the product. I then texted my father a photo of the product to which he told me he had ordered the exact one. I then texted him: “Good to know. You beat me to it. But I had to cross more variables :)”

What began as a request for paan shots, and a misinterpretation of text messages ended up in the above cascade of events.

But why the hell should we even care?

Great question! Let’s turn to every modern tech bro’s biggest worry (not really): energy costs.

And because I am lazy and fully support using AI for things that aren’t writing, I had Claude run the total energy costs of this text exchange. I kinda feel like an asshole making it run an analysis on energy costs, while simultaneously contributing to them, but whatever:

The numbers

Exchange rate used: ₹84.5 = \$1 USD (June 2026). PJM grid (NJ): 332 g CO2/kWh. India grid: 708 g CO2/kWh. Zeroed items absorbed by platforms or refunded.

GRAND TOTAL	ITEM COST	MARKUP	ENERGY COST
\$20.24	\$3.73	5.4×	\$0.018
All costs combined	The paan shots	From misinterpretation	0.09% of total

MONETARY BREAKDOWN

Cost item	Type	USD
Blinkit orders		
Paan shots — order 1 (friend’s UPI) ₹315 at ₹84.5/\$1	hard	\$3.73
Paan shots — order 2 (father’s order) Same product, fully refunded	zeroed	\$0.00
Blinkit platform fee ₹10–15 standard fee	hard	\$0.15
Blinkit delivery fee Hauz Khas, East Delhi est. ₹30–50	hard	\$0.47
Cancelled order driver dispatch Absorbed by Blinkit	zeroed	\$0.00
UPI merchant MDR ~0.3–0.9% absorbed by Blinkit		\$0.00
Money transfer		
Zelle to friend Sent \$5 to reimburse ₹315 + fees	hard	\$5.00
Zelle ACH settlement ~\$0.02–0.05, absorbed by banks	zeroed	\$0.00
USD/INR implicit conversion overage \$5 sent vs \$3.73 owed — friend kept ~\$1.27	hard	\$1.27
Communications		
WhatsApp calls — 6 calls, ~10 min total US–India VoIP; ~0.5MB/min	hard	\$0.01

WhatsApp messages — est. 25–40 texts across 7 people ~1–3KB per message	hard	<\$0.01
Find My Friends location ping Battery draw + data on mother's device	hard	<\$0.01
Opportunity costs		
Your time — ~25 min of coordination At \$20/hr student opportunity cost	opportunity	\$8.33
7 people interrupted across 2 countries Avg 3 min each at \$10/hr blended rate	opportunity	\$3.50
Father's duplicate coordination effort Independent Blinkit order set up in parallel	opportunity	\$1.67
Hard cost total		\$6.74
Opportunity cost total		~\$13.50
Grand total cost of one misread text		~\$20.24

ENERGY BREAKDOWN

Source	Energy	CO ₂
Delivery scooter — order 1 (completed) ~2.5 km round trip, 50 Wh/km, India grid	125 Wh	88.5 g
Delivery scooter — order 2 (cancelled, partial trip) Partial dispatch before cancellation	~60 Wh	42.5 g
MacBook (~25 min active) ~25W, PJM grid (NJ)	10.5 Wh	3.49 g
WhatsApp servers + all other devices 7 people, 6 calls, 25–40 messages	~4 Wh	~0.9 g
iPhone (~25 min active) ~3.5W, PJM grid (NJ)	1.47 Wh	0.49 g
Total energy consumed	~200 Wh	~136 g CO₂
Total energy cost in dollars	\$0.018 (0.09% of total)	

The paan shots cost \$3.73. The total cost of delivering them was \$20.24 — a 5.4× markup generated by one ambiguous text message. The scooters account for 92.5% of all energy consumed. Your phone and laptop are a rounding error on both measures.

I could care less about the personal costs, but I implore you to focus on Claude's stupidly estimated energy cost (note: I am not double checking its work because it's smart enough to estimate reasonably well and that's not the point of this essay). Even though I *was* able to have many personal “wins,” they still come at a micro-energetic cost.

Maybe next time I won't do the dishwasher when my ask me to do it. Why? Because I had already planned to do it *before* they had asked me; but now that they asked me, I don't feel like it anymore.